

Branta canadensis

Canada goose



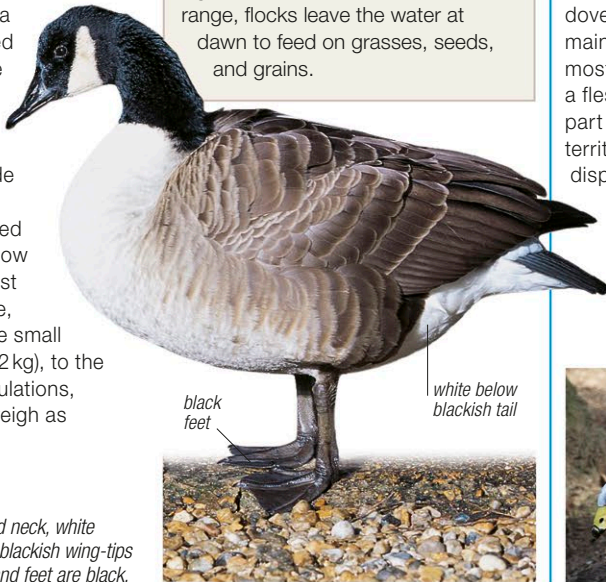
Length 22–39 in (55–100 cm)
Weight 4½–18 lb (2–8 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North America, N. Europe, N.E. Asia, New Zealand



Originally from North America, the highly sociable Canada goose has been introduced widely to Northern Europe and New Zealand. It is becoming increasingly common, a result of its ability to adapt to a wide range of climates, tolerate ecological change, and feed on grass as well as other low vegetation. One of the most variable of all geese in size, subspecies range from the small Arctic forms, up to 4½ lb (2 kg), to the large, most southerly populations, which may occasionally weigh as much as 18 lb (8 kg).

COLORATION
This goose has a black head and neck, white cheeks, and a brown body, with blackish wing-tips and lighter underparts. The bill and feet are black.



GRAZING



Canada geese are diurnal feeders, foraging on dry land as well as on water for plants. Now a common sight in parks outside their native range, flocks leave the water at dawn to feed on grasses, seeds, and grains.

Cereopsis novaehollandiae

Cape Barren goose

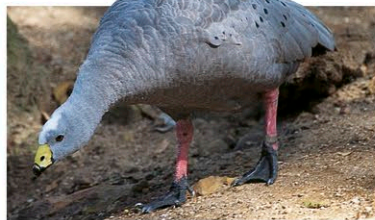


Length 30–36 in (75–91 cm)
Weight 8¾–13 lb (4–6 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location S. Australia (including offshore islands and Tasmania)



With reduced webbing on its toes, this dove-gray goose has adapted for life mainly on land. Its black, stubby bill is mostly hidden by a pale green cere—a fleshy pad at the base of the upper part of the bill. Aggressive and territorial, it performs several threat displays, and may bite or strike with its knobby wings. Mating occurs on land and is followed by a “triumph” ceremony by pairs after aggressive encounters with rival males.



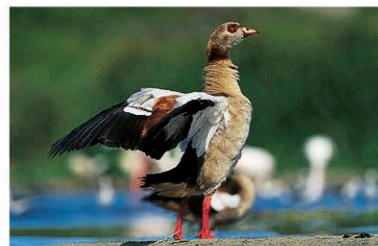
Alopochen aegyptiaca

Egyptian goose



Length 25–29 in (63–73 cm)
Weight 5½ lb (2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location Africa (south of Sahara)



A close relative of the common shelduck (see below, left), this long-legged bird lives in lakes, rivers, and subtropical wetlands, but also spends much of its time on land. Its “bullying” behavior toward smaller species is notable, as is its aggressive behavior within its own species. The female chooses the most aggressive male as a mate, which means there is much fighting during the pairing season. Males have husky calls, while females make loud, nattering sounds.

Tadorna tadorna

Common shelduck



Length 23–26½ in (58–67 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, N. Africa, E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, W. Pacific



An inhabitant chiefly of marine or saline waters, this duck has iridescent, greenish black, white, and chestnut plumage. The male has a knob at the top of its red bill, absent in the female (shown below). Like all shelducks, it is intermediate in behavior between a goose and a typical duck. It forages at the tide-line, usually standing in shallow water, probing for molluscs and other marine invertebrates. Nesting often takes place in holes, such as the abandoned burrows of other animals.



Anas platyrhynchos

Mallard



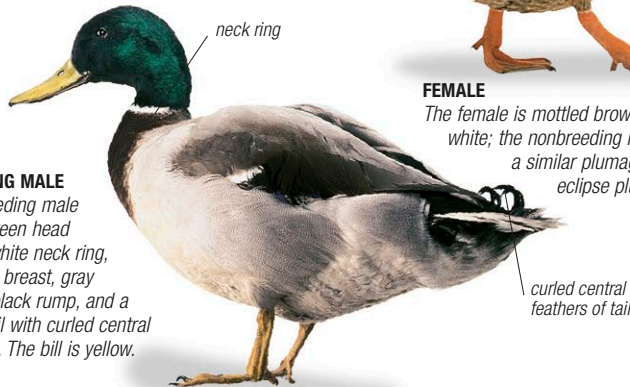
Length 20–25½ in (50–65 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North America, S. Greenland, Europe, Asia

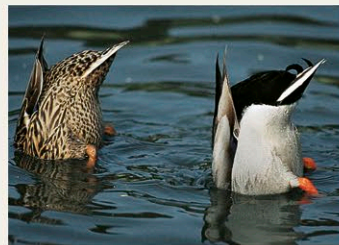


The mallard has a wide distribution in the Northern Hemisphere, its success being due to its great flexibility—it can adapt to almost all types of aquatic habitats for breeding, even urban environments, and is able to feed in a number of ways (see panel, right). The male has a low-pitched quack and a sharp whistle, while the female is more vocal and has many distinctive quacking calls

BREEDING MALE
The breeding male has a green head with a white neck ring, a rufous breast, gray flanks, black rump, and a white tail with curled central feathers. The bill is yellow.

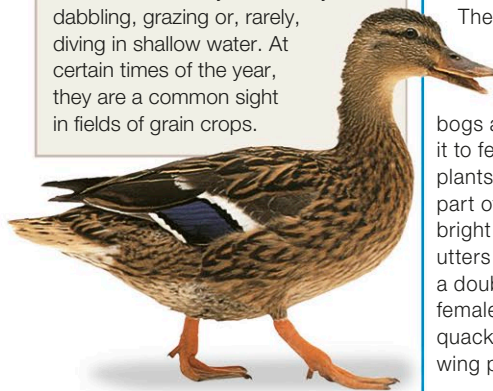


UP-ENDING



Mallards often feed by up-ending to reach submerged plants and invertebrates. They also eat by dabbling, grazing or, rarely, diving in shallow water. At certain times of the year, they are a common sight in fields of grain crops.

FEMALE
The female is mottled brown, buff, or white; the nonbreeding male has a similar plumage, called eclipse plumage.



Anas crecca

Eurasian teal



Length 13½–15 in (34–38 cm)
Weight 13 oz (350 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe (including Iceland), Asia, N. to C. Africa



The smallest dabbling duck, the Eurasian teal breeds in tundra, wet grassland, and beside small pools in bogs and moors. Its tiny bill helps it to feed on small seeds of aquatic plants; invertebrates also form part of its diet. The male has bright breeding plumage, and utters a cricketlike call that is a double-note whistle, while females produce high-pitched quacks. Both sexes have a green wing patch called “speculum.”

